

ON TECHNIQUE

Harmonic wizardry

For its time, Holst's musical language was often strikingly advanced and unfamiliar to audiences. He was the first English composer to explore thoroughly the technique of bitonality, where two different musical tonalities (or keys) are deployed together. In "Mercury, the Winged Messenger" in *The Planets*, the melodic line flickers between two opposite tonalities as if it belongs to neither, instead speeding weightlessly through the air. In "Neptune, the Mystic," pairs of harmonies (chords) in different tonalities, each in themselves quite traditional, are played one on top of the other, creating a sound of strange, other-worldly stillness out of the simplest musical components.

Gustav Holst was born in Cheltenham into a musical family of English, Scandinavian, and German ancestry. Health problems afflicted him all his life. Neuritis, which made his right arm feel like "a jelly overcharged with electricity," hampered his early promise as a pianist; he began playing the trombone at the age of 12, hoping that the activity might improve his tendency to asthma.

As a student at London's Royal College of Music, Holst met Ralph Vaughan Williams, who was to become his lifelong friend. Early in his career, he supported himself by playing the trombone in theater bands; he later joined the Carl Rosa Opera Company and the Scottish Orchestra (now the Royal Scottish National Orchestra), and worked as a church organist. While conducting the Hammersmith Socialist Choir, Holst fell in love with one of